



The Selectboard
TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027

Minutes of the Meeting
Monday, January 12, 2026, 7:00 PM
at the Town Hall, 1 South Road

A regular meeting of the Westhampton selectboard was held on Monday, January 12, 2026, 7:00 PM, at the Town Hall, 1 South Road. The meeting was held as a hybrid meeting via Zoom teleconferencing.

Call to Order

Meeting called to order by Chair Susan Bronstein at 7:01 PM.

PRESENT: Susan Bronstein, Scott Johndrow, Jen Milikowsky

ALSO PRESENT: Douglas Finn, others as noted below.

Public comment on any item not on the agenda

No public comment was offered.

Department Reports or Requests

Report - Fire Department

A written report of the hours worked by the Fire Chief was received and accepted as presented.

Request - Police Department – PT Hire

Police Chief David White requested permission to hire a part-time patrol officer for the remainder of FY2026. The proposal would provide some hours weekly for coverage in Westhampton, with potentially some hours dedicated to support of the town schools.

Ms. Milikowsky asked whether there was data that described response times for on-duty staff, versus response times for out-of-town coverage.

There was some discussion relative to the cost of adding the staff person versus the anticipated work product that might be realized.

Sergeant Jeff Fish: The goal is to get more officers on the street, to use more patrols to interact with the public, and to increase visibility in the community. We would be using funds that we have in our budget for the current year.

Ms. Milikowsky asked if adding another patrolman made sense given the anticipated cuts to the budget.

There was continued discussion about the need, and the potential for ‘diminishing returns’ – expending more funds to get no reportable or observable benefit.

There was some discussion about providing coverage for the regional school, and whether there could be some funds from the school to help fund the position.

Chief White: The request is to fund the position through the end of the year, with future employment subject to appropriation.

Q: What would your justification for increased staffing be to town meeting? Chief White: We’re

responding to town resident concerns, and have increased traffic enforcement efforts by 75%; that takes staff time.

Q: What would your process be? A: If approved, we would accept applications, conduct interviews, and recommend a candidate to the Selectboard for appointment.

The details of the appropriation for FY26 were reviewed.

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To allow the Police Chief to accept applications for a part-time officer, with hours not to exceed the current appropriation.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (7:20 PM)

Other Department Reports

Highway Superintendent Bill Jablonski

Mr. Jablonski reviewed work performed from early December through current week, including snow removal, catch-basin cleanup, equipment service and maintenance; crew also assisted with fire response in Chesterfield; Mr. Jablonski noted that due to geography, partial road treatment is often needed in early mornings.

Mr. Jablonski spoke briefly about the benefits of buying quality cutting edges for snowplows, which reduce maintenance and cost.

Mr. Jablonski asked for permission to overspend the snow and ice budget, noting that at last count, \$17,683 remained in the snow and ice budget.

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve exceeding the appropriation for fund # 015423.700 "Snow Removal" in accordance with the provisions of Chapter 44, Section 31D.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0 (7:32 PM)

Committees

Finance Committee – Tad Weiss

Mr. Tad Weiss, Chair of the Finance Committee, spoke briefly about the status of the FY2027 budget development and the anticipated budget process.

There was discussion about the requested reductions to budgets, and where budgets sit now.

Mr. Weiss raised the issue of the schedule, noting that a draft of the School Budgets would likely not be in the hands of the finance committee until March 18, and that a decision about a potential Proposition 2-1/2 override could be considered within the next two weeks after.

Mr. Weiss noted that he has communicated the need to develop a school budget "conservatively and quickly". He also stated that he is planning on at least two public hearings to present the budget and answer questions for the public.

Mr. Weiss suggested that the Proposition 2-1/2 'cap' was limiting the town to the point of unsustainability, the town was, fiscally, being pushed 'over the edge'. Mr. Weiss suggested that a Prop 2-1/2 override is going to be a hard-sell, but "we have to try".

Mr. Johndrow noted that Westhampton has 'historically supported our schools', and that he hope that they

would understand the help that the Town needs at this time.

Mr. Weiss noted that Town meeting decisions would likely be predicated on members' choices at Town Meeting, the levels at which budgets are supported, and town meeting members decisions on a Prop 2-1/2 override question.

Mr. Steve Holt noted his belief that, in order to meet budget challenges, he believed that staff would need to be cut. Ms. Milikowsky noted that revenue was the other half of the equation, and the consistent reduction in state aid.

There was some discussion about the inequities relative to state aid reimbursement.

Other Reports

No other reports presented.

Administrative

Review – First draft of Annual Town Report

Selectboard directed the Annual Town Report would be in digital format only, with a very limited (less than ten) copies for placement at the Town Hall and Library for review.

Review – Letter of Attestation relative to Tob Hill Road Land Acquisition

Selectboard to review letter attesting that land to be acquired on Tob Hill Road will remain in conservation restriction in accordance with Article 97 of the Massachusetts Constitution and other regulations or statutes. Vote anticipated.

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To approve the letter and to sign.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (8:08 PM)

Town Coordinator Report

Town Coordinator to report on recent activity on projects or events. Consensus advice and direction on any topic may be given.

Mr. Finn presented a draft letter of support for H.3132, a local-option bill that would give the town the potential for a tax abatement for local EMTs and volunteer firefighters. The bill requires local adoption, and would allow the town to create a program that provided up to \$2,500 per year in tax relief.

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To approve the letter, and to sign.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (8:15 PM)

The board reviewed a grant contract relative to the FY26 Round of the Community One Stop for Growth, a grant in the amount of \$168,000 from the Rural Development Fund, approved to support the Pine Island Culvert Repairs.

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve the contract, and authorize Ms. Bronstein to sign on behalf of the board.

VOTED 3, 0, 0. (8:29 PM)

Selectboard Reports

Selectboard members may report on recent activity on any town project, board or committee. Consensus advice and direction on any topic may be given.

Ms. Bronstein reported on the Boston Post Cane Award program from Saturday the 10th of January, where the award was given to Jessie Krug. Ms. Bronstein noted that the reception was very well attended, and the recipient was very grateful for the honor.

Selectboard Member Concerns

Selectboard members may raise topics of new business or propose future action items. Consensus advice and direction on any topic may be given.

Mr. Johndrow asked for a discussion item to be placed on the next agenda in regard to contract review. Ms. Bronstein agreed.

Review of Correspondence if any

Correspondence was reviewed. No action taken on any item.

Review and Approve A/P and Payroll Warrants #W26-14

M: Johndrow 2: Milikowsky

To approve.

VOTED: (8:30 PM)

Review and Approve Minutes if available

M:Mili 2:Johndrow

To approve the minutes.

VOTE: 3, 0, 0 (8:31 PM)

Request for Executive Session

Mr. Finn requested an executive Session for follow-up deliberations relative to a personnel issue, and to approve previous Executive Session minutes.

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To enter into executive session to review minutes of a previous executive session, pursuant to G.L. c.30A, § 21(a)(7) "[t]o comply with, or act under the authority of, any general or special law or federal grant-in-aid requirements", and to discuss matters relative to a personnel issue.

VOTED: JOHNDROW: YES; MILIKOWSKY: YES; BRONSTEIN: YES. (8:32 PM)

Executive Session

Mr. Finn provided follow-up information relative to the matter previously discussed by the board in executive session on December 29, 2025. After reviewing the current payroll, and with brief deliberation, the board agreed to take no further action on the matter.

Mr. Finn presented minutes of the Executive Session of December 29, 2025 for review. After review, it

was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve the minutes of the December 29, 2025 Executive Session as presented.

VOTED: JOHNDROW: YES; MILIKOWSKY: YES; BRONSTEIN: YES. (8:32 PM)

Mr. Johndrow asked for clarification as to how long executive session minutes would remain embargoed. Mr. Finn noted that the Selectboard has the right to determine how long they may be withheld from disclosure, but may do so only as long as publication would defeat the lawful purpose of the session. For certain items, such as personnel related issues, that time could potentially be indefinite.

Adjourn

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To Adjourn.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (8:37 PM)

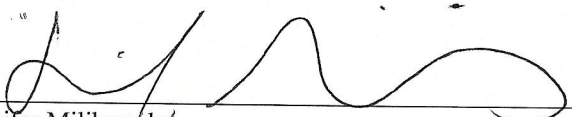
Approved by a vote of the Selectboard at a regular meeting, held on January 26, 2025.



Susan Bronstein



Scott Johndrow



Jennifer Milikowsky